

The AI Operations Playbook

for small businesses

A no-jargon guide to removing the busywork — pick the right tasks, and let AI run them without you.

START HERE

You're not short on AI. You're short on the right AI.

Most owners have tried ChatGPT and felt the gap between a cool demo and something that actually gives them time back. The problem usually isn't the model — it's that nobody picked the right task and built it to run without a human babysitting it.

This is the operator's version: which busywork to hand to AI, how to spot your best first automation, and what a good one actually looks like. No prompts to memorise — just judgment you can use this week.

WHERE TO LOOK

The five buckets worth automating first.

- 01 Admin & paperwork.** Invoices, quotes, data entry, sorting documents.
- 02 Customer comms.** Replies, FAQs, follow-ups, review requests.
- 03 Marketing & content.** Posts, repurposing, first-draft copy, image assets.
- 04 Data & reporting.** Turning a messy spreadsheet into one clear answer.
- 05 Scheduling & ops.** Bookings, routing, reminders, hand-offs.

If a task is frequent, rule-based, and eats real hours — it's a candidate.

PICK ONE

How to pick the one that pays off.

Score each candidate task 1–5 on three things, then multiply:

- ✕ **Frequency** — how often it happens (daily beats quarterly).
- ✕ **Time** — the hours it actually eats.
- ✕ **Rules** — how repeatable and clear the steps are.

Start with the highest score.
Automate the boring thing you do every day — not the clever thing you do once a quarter.

THE BAR

A tool, not a toy.

- It **runs without you** — no copy-pasting into a chat every time.
- It does **one job, end to end**.
- It handles the **messy cases** — empty, wrong, missing — not just the happy path.
- You measure it by the **hours it gives back**, not how clever it feels.

If a human still has to babysit it,
it's a demo — not an automation.

THE PLAN

From idea to running in a week.

Mon Pick one, using the scorecard.

Tue Scope it tight — one job, clear inputs and outputs.

W–Th Build the smallest version that actually works.

Fri Test it on real inputs. Keep it, or bin it.

Tight scope is the whole trick.
"Automate my ops" fails; "draft every review-request text" ships.

YOUR MOVE

Do it yourself — or don't.

You can build a lot of this with today's tools and a focused weekend. Bring in help when the task touches money, customers, or data you can't afford to get wrong — or when you'd rather skip the learning curve and have it running by next week.

I build these for small businesses — fixed scope, about a week.

Book a free 15-minute call and we'll find your highest-payoff automation.

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